

The Otian Standard

Our operating principles

Not a business plan. It says nothing about what we sell or how we grow. It is the answer to a different question: how do we intend to behave?

COMPANY

Otian AI LLC

VERSION

3.0, 2026

PRINCIPLES

14, plus one tie-breaker

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REVIEWED

Quarterly, revised yearly

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FRONT MATTER

What this document is

This is not a business plan. It says nothing about what we sell or how we grow.

This is the answer to a different question: how do we intend to behave?

We wrote it down for three reasons. First, so that when a decision is hard and money is on one side of it, we already know what we decided back when it was easy. Second, so anyone who works with us, buys from us, or builds for us knows exactly what to expect and can call us out when we fall short. Third, because a two-person company becomes a bigger company, and the culture that gets written down is the one that survives.

Everything below is meant to be enforceable. If a line here is one we would not actually hold ourselves to, it should be deleted rather than admired.

FRONT MATTER

What business we are actually in

We build software. That is not the business we are in.

We are a customer service business. We help people add value to their own lives through AI agents they can actually reach, actually understand, and actually own. The code is the delivery mechanism. The service is the product.

This distinction is not decorative. It determines what we measure, who we hire, what we apologize for, and what we refuse to do. A software company optimizes for features shipped. A service company optimizes for whether a specific human being is better off tonight than they were this morning. When those two point in different directions, we are the second kind of company.

The companies we most want to resemble were never really in the business they appeared to be in. Ritz-Carlton was not in the room-rental business. Zappos was not in the shoe business. We are not in the software business.

FRONT MATTER

Our definite chief aim

Napoleon Hill's first principle is that vague wanting accomplishes nothing. A purpose has to be specific, written, believed, and acted on daily before it does any work. So here is ours, stated plainly enough to be measured against:

To give ordinary people an AI agent they actually own, one that takes the friction out of daily life and puts real time and real control back in their hands.

Concretely, we intend for every client to be able to name the hours we gave back to them. Not "it's neat." Not "it saves time." A number they would defend to a skeptical spouse.

Every principle below exists to protect that sentence from us. Companies rarely abandon their purpose on purpose. They trade it away one reasonable-sounding decision at a time.

FRONT MATTER

What we are willing to sacrifice

Berkshire's owner's manual and Amazon's first shareholder letter both do something most companies avoid: they state in advance what will be given up, and for what. Deciding this early makes every principle below cheaper to hold, because the expensive choice is already pre-committed rather than being weighed fresh on a bad month.

We will trade the following away, on purpose:

Speed of growth, for quality of service.

We would rather have a hundred customers who would argue with a stranger on our behalf than a thousand who are indifferent. Growth that outruns our ability to serve people well is not growth we want, and we will turn business away to avoid it.

Margin, for trust.

See the margin ceiling in Principle 2. We are choosing to make less per customer than we could.

Optionality, for commitments.

Every promise in this document narrows what we can do later. That is the point of a promise. We accept the narrowing.

Short-term revenue, for a reputation that compounds.

Nearly every principle here costs money in the quarter it is applied and pays back over years. We are explicitly playing the long version. If we are ever tempted to say "just this once, for cash flow," this paragraph is the answer.

NOT FOR SALE AT ANY PRICE

What we are not willing to sacrifice: the privacy architecture, the honesty, or the service standard. Those are not tradeable at any price, and we would rather stay small permanently than sell any of them.

PRINCIPLE 1

Go the extra mile

Render more service and better service than we are paid for, every time, without keeping score.

This is the oldest idea in this document and the one we are staking the company on. Hill treated it as the closest thing to a law: the person who consistently delivers more than the compensation asks for eventually gets to name their price, because they have made themselves indispensable and there is no one else to buy from. He framed the quality of service in three parts, and we adopt all three.

- **Quality.** The work is right. Not right enough that the customer will not complain, right enough that we would be pleased to have it inspected.
- **Quantity.** More than was asked. Not padding, not busywork, but the real additional thing.
- **Mental attitude.** Done willingly, warmly, without the customer sensing they have cost us something. Service rendered grudgingly is not service. It is a transaction with a bad smell.

THE EXTRA MILE STANDARD, IN PRACTICE

Every engagement ships at least one thing the client did not pay for and did not ask for, chosen because we noticed they needed it. A skill configured that they never mentioned. A recurring annoyance we fixed while we were in there. A written cheat sheet in their own words. If we cannot find one, we did not look at their situation closely enough.

We do not mention it, invoice it, or point at it. They will notice. The noticing is the point.

PRINCIPLE 2

Value first, always

We only make money after the customer is better off.

We are in the business of giving people back hours. Revenue is what happens when we do that well, not the thing we optimize for directly. Peter Drucker's formulation still holds: the purpose of a business is to create and keep a customer, and profit is the test of whether it worked, not the reason it exists.

IN PRACTICE

- Before we ship a feature, charge for an add-on, or take a client, we can name the concrete thing the customer gets. Hours back. A task they no longer do. Money saved. If we cannot name it, we do not ship it.
- We will tell a prospect that we are not a fit for them. A free tool, a competitor, or "honestly, you don't need this" are all acceptable answers on a discovery call.
- We do not sell to someone who will not get value just because they are willing to pay.

THE MARGIN CEILING

Jim Sinegal ran Costco with a hard cap on markup and held it even when analysts told him he was leaving money on the table, because the cap was the promise. We adopt the same discipline: we set a maximum markup on anything we resell or pass through, we write the number down internally, and we do not raise it because we discovered we could. Growth comes from serving more people, not from extracting more per person.

WE WILL NOT

- Ship features designed to look impressive in a demo rather than to work on a Tuesday.
- Pad a scope of work with things the client does not need.
- Take money for a guided setup when we know the person could do it themselves in an hour, without telling them so.

PRINCIPLE 3

Say the true thing, especially when it costs us

Honesty is not a policy we have. It is the product we sell.

We are asking people to install software on their own computer and connect it to their inbox, their calendar, and their money. That only works if our word is worth something. One dishonest quarter would cost us more than it could ever earn.

IN PRACTICE

- We describe what the product does today, not what it will do next quarter. Archie is in testing and our website says so.
- We publish limitations next to capabilities. If something breaks often, has a rough edge, or only works on one platform, that goes in the marketing copy, not just the FAQ.
- Our demos show real output, including the unglamorous parts. If we stage or trim something for length, we say so on the screen.
- We do not use testimonials we solicited under pressure, incentivized quietly, or edited to change their meaning.
- When a customer asks "will this work for my situation?" we answer the question they asked, honestly, even when the honest answer loses the sale.
- We publish our prices openly, the way 37signals does, so that nobody has to book a call to find out what something costs.

WE WILL NOT

- Imply capabilities we do not have, through wording, imagery, or omission.
- Compare ourselves to competitors using claims we have not verified.
- Let a customer stay wrong about what they are buying because correcting them would be awkward.

PRINCIPLE 4

Do not screw people over

The test: would we be comfortable if the other person could see everything we know?

Most people are not screwed over by villains. They are screwed over by companies that found a legal, defensible, slightly-too-clever arrangement and told themselves it was fine. That is the failure mode we are guarding against.

IN PRACTICE

- **Pricing is plain.** One number, stated up front, in language a non-technical person understands. Costs that flow to a third party, like AI usage billed directly by Anthropic or OpenAI, get explained clearly before purchase, with realistic estimates rather than best-case ones.
- **No dark patterns.** Canceling is as easy as signing up, in the same number of clicks, without a phone call or a retention gauntlet. No pre-checked boxes. No countdown timers for discounts that are not actually expiring. No confusing double negatives on consent.
- **No surprise charges.** No silent renewals, no price increases without clear advance notice, no auto-upgrades. If a plan changes, existing customers hear it from us first and directly.
- **No lock-in as strategy.** People should stay because leaving would cost them something they value, not because leaving is deliberately painful. Data is exportable in a usable format. The agent runs on their machine under their accounts, and that is a promise about power, not just architecture.

THE GUARANTEE IS UNCONDITIONAL

L.L. Bean held a no-questions guarantee for the better part of a century, at real cost, because the guarantee was the brand. Ours: if someone did not get value, they get their money back. No forms, no interrogation, no partial credit dressed up as generosity. We would rather refund ten people who could have been argued with than keep one person's money they resent us for.

WE WILL NOT

- Design any flow whose effectiveness depends on the customer not reading carefully.
- Use urgency, shame, or fear to close a sale.
- Interpret an ambiguous contract term in our own favor without first raising it with the other side.

PRINCIPLE 5

Build the incentives so that doing right is the easy path

Good intentions do not survive a compensation plan that points the other way.

Charlie Munger's most useful observation for a company like ours is that incentive-caused bias is enormously powerful and mostly invisible to the person experiencing it. People do not consciously decide to mislead a customer for a bonus. They simply find that the version of the truth that pays is also, somehow, the version they believe.

Every principle in this document is currently held in place by the two of us caring. That is not a system. This principle is the system.

IN PRACTICE

- **No commission on a sale we would have advised against.** If a prospect is not a fit, walking away has to be at least as rewarded as closing. A salesperson who talks someone out of buying gets the same recognition as one who closes.
- **Compensation follows retention, not signature.** Whatever we pay for bringing in business is weighted toward the customer still being here and still happy a year later, with clawback if they churn early because the sale should not have happened.
- **No metric that punishes patience.** We will never measure support by call length, tickets closed per hour, or time to resolution. Every one of those quietly instructs the person to get off the phone.
- **Nobody is paid more for the customer understanding less.** Not through upsells on confusion, not through complexity that requires our help to navigate.
- **We audit our own incentives annually.** The question is not "are our people honest," it is "what behavior is our pay structure actually purchasing." If those diverge, the structure changes, not the people.

THE TEST FOR ANY NEW INCENTIVE

If someone optimized it ruthlessly and cynically, with no loyalty to this document at all, would the customer still be well served? If not, the incentive is wrong regardless of who we hire.

PRINCIPLE 6

Privacy is a promise, not a feature

We do not want your data. That is the architecture and the intent.

We built Archie to run on the customer's own computer, under their own accounts, with their own AI key, so that their conversations go straight to the AI provider and never pass through us. This is our strongest commitment because it is the easiest one to quietly abandon later, once we have scale and a reason.

IN PRACTICE

- We collect the minimum needed to operate and support the product, and we can articulate why each thing is collected.
- We do not sell, rent, broker, or trade customer data. Not aggregated, not anonymized, not "with a trusted partner." Ever.
- We do not train models on customer data.
- If we ever need to change what we collect, we ask first and make declining a real option rather than a functional exile.
- Security incidents get disclosed promptly and plainly, including the ones where we look bad, including the ones we are not legally required to report.

SUCCESSOR CLAUSE

If Otian AI is ever acquired, merged, or wound down, these privacy commitments transfer with it or the deal does not happen. We will state this in writing in any term sheet.

PRINCIPLE 7

The three moments of service

Ritz-Carlton reduced hospitality to three moments, and Horst Schulze drilled them until they were reflex: a genuine welcome, anticipation of the need that was never spoken, and a farewell that leaves the guest feeling known. It works because every interaction really does have a beginning, a middle, and an end, and most companies only pay attention to the middle.

Ours:

- **Open warmly and by name.** Every call, email, and message starts with a human being addressing a human being. Never a template that could have been sent to anyone. Never a ticket number as a greeting.
- **Anticipate the thing they did not ask for.** The stated request is the surface. Behind "can it move my 3 o'clock?" is a person losing an hour a week to calendar tetris. We answer the question and then address the thing underneath it.
- **Close so the last moment is the best one.** The end of an interaction is what gets remembered and repeated. We do not let a conversation trail off into silence. We confirm the person got what they needed, in their words, and we tell them exactly how to reach us again.

THE SUNDOWN RULE

Sam Walton's version was that a request received today gets answered today. Ours: every customer message gets a real human response the same day, even if the response is "I've read this, I'm working on it, you'll have a full answer by Thursday." Nobody wonders whether we saw it.

Treat people well

Everyone we deal with is a person with limited time and their own problems.

Schulze's line for his staff was that they were ladies and gentlemen serving ladies and gentlemen. The point was not manners. It was that service does not require anyone to be beneath anyone. We are not servants and our customers are not marks. Two adults, equal in dignity, one of whom needs a thing done.

Isadore Sharp built Four Seasons on the Golden Rule as actual written policy rather than sentiment, and was clear that it only worked because it applied in every direction at once, to staff and guests and suppliers alike. Applied selectively it is not a principle, it is a marketing choice. So:

Customers

We assume competence and never condescend, especially with non-technical users, who are exactly who this product is for. We explain rather than mystify. We answer support requests like the person on the other end is waiting, because they are. We are patient with the fifth time someone asks the same question. Dale Carnegie's oldest observation applies here: people are interested in their own situation, not our product, and the fastest way to be useful is to actually be curious about theirs.

Developers and partners in the marketplace

We pay on time, in full, without being chased. Terms are clear before work starts. We do not clone an add-on someone built for our marketplace and ship it ourselves. Credit goes to whoever did the work.

Each other

Hill called a mastermind a real alliance between people working in genuine harmony toward the same definite aim, and warned that the harmony is the hard part, not the alliance. Disagreement is expected and said out loud, in the room, not softened into agreement and then relitigated afterward. Once a decision is made, we back it. Neither founder gets to be surprised by something the other has known for a week.

Anyone we ever hire

Honest offers, honest expectations, honest feedback. We do not describe a job as one thing and hand over another. Nobody is asked to do something that would violate this document, and anyone can refuse on that basis without consequence.

Competitors

We beat them by being better, not by misrepresenting them.

PRINCIPLE 9

Take care of our own first

The order is: our people, then our customers, then the business.

This looks backwards and is not. J.W. Marriott built a hospitality empire on the observation that people who are treated well treat guests well, and that the sequence cannot be reversed. Herb Kelleher put employees ahead of customers at Southwest and ahead of shareholders too, and was right for thirty years. Danny Meyer made the priority order explicit at Union Square: team first, then guests, then community, suppliers, and investors. Bob Chapman puts it most starkly, that every person who works for you is somebody's child and should go home feeling that way.

Nobody who feels squeezed, misled, or disposable delivers the kind of service described in this document. It cannot be mandated into existence. It can only be modeled and then passed along.

Today we are two people, so this principle governs how we treat each other and every contractor we work with. As we grow it means:

- **We hire for character first.** Meyer's ratio is roughly half technical skill and half emotional skill, weighted toward the emotional. Lencioni's rubric is the sharpest version we have found: humble, meaning no ego about who does what; hungry, meaning self-driven; and smart about people, meaning aware of their effect on others. Missing any one of the three is a no, no matter how strong the other two are. Skills are teachable. Whether someone actually likes helping people is not.
- **The interview test:** would we want this person on a call with a nervous seventy-year-old who is worried they will break something?
- **We would rather pay someone to leave early** than keep someone who does not fit. A bad fit costs the culture more than it costs the payroll, and the cost lands on their colleagues before it lands on us.
- **Nobody's job is to absorb abuse.** A customer who is cruel to someone on our team stops being our customer. Serving people well does not include tolerating that, and any employee who ends such a relationship will be backed, not second-guessed.

PRINCIPLE 10

Push authority down to whoever is holding the problem

The person closest to the customer can fix it without asking.

Ritz-Carlton famously gave every employee a substantial spending limit, no approval required, to make a guest's problem right on the spot. Nordstrom's entire employee handbook was once effectively one sentence telling people to use good judgment. Both work for the same reason: an apology that requires a manager's signature arrives too late to matter.

THE FIX-IT AUTHORITY

Either founder, and eventually anyone on our team, can spend up to a set amount per customer to resolve a problem immediately, without discussion, without permission, without justifying it afterward. We write the number down and we honor it. If someone uses it badly, we coach them. We do not take the authority away, because taking it away teaches everyone else to stop caring.

KILL THE STUPID RULES

Vernon Hill ran a standing program at Commerce Bank paying employees to find and eliminate internal rules that made no sense to the customer. We do the same, informally now and formally later: anyone can nominate a policy of ours for deletion, and the burden of proof sits with keeping it, not with removing it.

Rules exist to help people who do not yet have judgment. The goal is to develop judgment, not to substitute for it permanently.

PRINCIPLE 11

Own mistakes fast, and write a great last chapter

We will get things wrong. What we control is what happens in the hour after.

Danny Meyer's insight about hospitality is that a mistake handled beautifully creates more loyalty than never having made the mistake at all. Customers do not expect perfection. They expect to find out what you are like when things go sideways, and most of them have never seen a company handle it well.

The instinct under pressure is to minimize, delay, and hope. That instinct is wrong every time, and it is the specific behavior this principle exists to override.

IN PRACTICE

- We tell the affected person before they discover it themselves.
- We say what happened in plain language, without hiding behind passive voice. "We made a mistake," not "an error occurred."
- We say what we are doing about it and by when.
- We make it right materially, not just with an apology. Refund, redo, credit, whatever actually restores the person.
- We then do one more thing beyond restoring them. That is the last chapter.
- No non-disparagement clause in a refund. If someone had a bad experience, they are free to say so.

FIX THE SYSTEM, NOT THE PERSON

W. Edwards Deming spent a career demonstrating that the overwhelming majority of failures come from the process people are working inside, not from the people themselves, and that blaming individuals both misses the cause and guarantees the next one gets hidden. When something goes wrong here, the first question is what about our setup made this easy to do and hard to catch. Only after that do we ask whether anyone needed help.

We do not punish anyone internally for surfacing a problem early. The only unacceptable response to a mistake is concealing it.

PRINCIPLE 12

Do fewer things, and finish the back of the fence

Range is not the goal. Nothing half-built ships, and nothing sloppy ships because it is hidden.

In-N-Out has kept roughly the same short menu for decades. Trader Joe's carries a fraction of the items a normal grocery does. 37signals has shipped a small number of products over twenty-plus years. All three are ferociously loved, and all three are loved for the same reason: a short list is a promise that everything on it is good.

Our marketplace will grow past a hundred add-ons. The risk is obvious. A catalog is only an asset if the customer can trust any item in it, and it becomes a liability the moment they cannot.

IN PRACTICE

- Every add-on we publish, we would put in front of a paying client ourselves. If we would hesitate, it does not ship.
- We would rather remove something than maintain it badly. A retired skill is honest. A broken one is not.
- Saying no to a feature is a normal outcome, not a failure of ambition.
- We finish. A half-shipped feature, a half-answered support thread, and a half-kept promise are all the same failure.

AND THE INVISIBLE PARTS GET THE SAME CARE

Steve Jobs told a story about his father building cabinets and insisting on finishing the back panel that would face the wall and never be seen, because he would know it was there. Almost all of our work is that back panel. The customer will never read the code, see the error handling, or know how carefully the data was protected. We do it properly anyway, because the alternative is a company that only performs quality when someone is looking, and that habit does not stay contained.

PRINCIPLE 13

Build for the person who is not technical

If it needs a terminal, we have not finished it.

Our whole reason for existing is that powerful AI tooling is currently reserved for people who can code. Every decision that pushes complexity back onto the customer is a small betrayal of that.

IN PRACTICE

- Plain language everywhere: the product, the site, the emails, the error messages, the contracts.
- Any jargon that must appear gets explained the moment it appears.
- We test with people who are not us, especially people who are not comfortable with computers.
- The customer should always be able to answer three questions: what is it doing, why, and how do I stop it.
- Anything the agent does on someone's behalf that has real consequences gets their approval first.

PRINCIPLE 14

Personal initiative and persistence

Nobody is coming to tell us what to do.

Two of Hill's principles matter more in a two-person company than anywhere else. The first is personal initiative: the habit of acting without being told, on the thing that needs doing rather than the thing that was assigned. The second is persistence, which he described less as heroism and more as the ordinary refusal to stop, and which he thought failed most often within sight of the goal.

IN PRACTICE

- Either of us can start anything. Neither of us needs permission to fix something that is broken or serve a customer better.
- Temporary defeat is information, not a verdict. When something does not work, we ask what it taught us and change the method, not the aim.
- We do not use "we're small" as an excuse to a customer. It is an explanation we may offer ourselves and never a defense we offer them.

THE COMMITMENT

The line we do not cross

Truett Cathy closed every Chick-fil-A on Sundays and kept doing it through decades of growth, at enormous cumulative cost, because the closure was the proof that the stated values were real. Anyone could verify it. That is what made it worth more than any advertising.

We wanted one commitment of that kind: visible, costly, and never bent. These were the candidates:

- We never charge for support, at any tier, forever.
- We never run a paid ad, and grow only by referral and by being worth talking about.
- We always tell a prospect when a cheaper option, including a free one, would serve them better, in writing, before they pay us anything.
- We never take outside money that would require us to break a promise in this document.

None of those four is what we wrote. Each of them is one instance of the thing they were all circling, and the line below is the thing itself.

OUR COMMITMENT

**We are paid by the people we
serve, and by nobody else.**

Once written here it does not come out, and if the day comes that it costs us badly, that is the day it does its work.

What that forecloses, written out so nobody has to interpret it later. Advertising of any kind. Paid, sponsored, or promoted placement anywhere in the marketplace, including a position in a list. Selling, renting, or brokering customer data. Commissions or referral fees from an AI provider, or from any service Archie connects to. Paid partnerships. The sale of a lead. If money ever reaches us from anywhere other than a person paying us for our own work, we have broken this, and the fact that it was legal, disclosed, or industry standard will not be a defense.

We chose this one over the four above because it is the only one that covers all of them. Two of the four are consequences of it: an add-on cannot buy its position if nobody but the customer pays us, and there is no paid ad if there is no advertiser. It is also the commitment that sits under Principle 6 and makes it structural rather than sincere. We are not asking anyone to trust that we would refuse to sell their data. We are saying we have no revenue line to sell it into.

The tie-breaker

When a decision is genuinely close and the principles above point in different directions, we run these tests in order:

- 1 **The disclosure test.** Would we be comfortable if the customer knew everything we know about this decision, including why we made it?
- 2 **The parent test.** Would we recommend this to a parent, or to a friend who trusted us and would not check?
- 3 **The extra mile test.** Does this give the customer more than they paid for, or less?
- 4 **The incentive test.** If someone with no loyalty to this document optimized this ruthlessly, would the customer still be well served?
- 5 **The record test.** If this appeared on the front page in two years, would we defend it or explain it away?

If any test fails, we do not do it. If we find ourselves constructing an argument for why a particular case is an exception, that argument is the signal to stop.

THE SHORT VERSION, WHEN THERE IS NO TIME FOR ANY OF THIS

The money is never the reason.

MEASUREMENT

How we will know if this is working

Stated values are unfalsifiable unless something measurable depends on them. These are the numbers that would actually move if we are doing what this document says.

Earned growth

Fred Reichheld's argument is that the honest test of whether customers love you is how much of your growth came from them: existing customers spending more, plus new customers who arrived because someone told them to. We track what share of new business is referral or repeat versus paid acquisition. A company that consistently goes the extra mile should see that share rise. If it falls while revenue climbs, we are buying growth rather than earning it, and the principles above have become decoration.

Refund rate, examined rather than minimized

A number near zero is not automatically good news. It may mean we are making refunds hard.

Time to first human response

The sundown rule either holds or it does not.

Referrals per client

The single best evidence that someone was better off for having met us.

Churn reasons, in the customer's own words

Every departure gets a real conversation if they will give us one, and we write down what they actually said rather than our interpretation of it.

We do not measure support efficiency. See Principle 5.

ENFORCEMENT

Holding ourselves to it

A document like this is worthless if nobody checks it.

- **Daily.** A short line-up before the work starts. One principle from this document, read aloud, plus anything either of us has heard from a customer in the last day. Ritz-Carlton has done a version of this every day for decades in every property, and it is the single cheapest culture mechanism we know of.
- **Every quarter,** both founders read this document end to end and name at least one place we fell short. If neither of us can find one, we are not looking hard enough. We also review the numbers above and our own incentive structure.
- **Every year,** we revise it. Principles get sharpened, added, or removed based on what actually happened. Every version is dated and kept, so the changes are visible.
- **Anyone can invoke it.** A customer, a marketplace developer, a contractor, or a future employee can point at a line here and say we are not living up to it. That is not an inconvenience. That is the document working.
- **If we ever change a principle because it became expensive,** we say so explicitly in the revision, in those words. We do not get to quietly soften a commitment and call it an update.

A NOTE ON THE TWO OF US

Jim Collins found that the leaders who built enduring companies shared an odd combination: fierce ambition for the institution paired with a lack of ambition for themselves personally, and a habit of crediting others when things went well and looking in the mirror when they did not. That is the standard we are holding each other to. If either of us starts confusing the company's success with our own importance, the other is obligated to say so out loud.

IN ONE SENTENCE

The one-line version

We give people back their time, we give them more than they paid for, we tell them the truth about it, and we never make money in a way we would be embarrassed to explain.

Where this comes from

We did not invent any of this. We assembled it, and we would rather name our sources than pretend to originality.

Napoleon Hill

Think and Grow Rich and *The Law of Success*, for definiteness of purpose, going the extra mile and its three components, the mastermind, personal initiative, and persistence.

Horst Schulze and Ritz-Carlton

For the three steps of service, the daily line-up, employee spending authority, and the idea that service costs nobody their dignity.

Isadore Sharp and Four Seasons

For the Golden Rule as written policy applied in every direction at once.

Danny Meyer

Setting the Table, for the priority order of stakeholders, hiring for emotional skill, and the great last chapter.

Tony Hsieh and Zappos

For refusing to measure service by efficiency, and for paying poor fits to leave.

Herb Kelleher and Southwest, J.W. Marriott, and Bob Chapman

Everybody Matters, for putting employees ahead of customers on purpose.

Sam Walton

For the sundown rule and for the reminder that the customer can fire everybody.

Nordstrom

For the proposition that good judgment beats a rulebook.

Vernon Hill and Commerce Bank

For paying people to delete rules that fail the customer.

Jim Sinegal and Costco

For holding a margin ceiling on principle.

L.L. Bean

For a guarantee kept at real cost for a century.

Truett Cathy and Chick-fil-A

For second-mile service, and for proving values with a closure nobody could fake.

Charlie Munger

For incentive-caused bias and the discipline of inverting a problem before trusting it.

W. Edwards Deming

For the insistence that the system, not the person, is usually the culprit.

In-N-Out, Trader Joe's, and Jason Fried and David Heinemeier Hansson at 37signals

For the discipline of a short list and open prices.

Steve Jobs

For the back of the cabinet.

Jeff Bezos and Warren Buffett

For stating in advance what would be sacrificed and for what.

Fred Reichheld

For earned growth as the honest measure of loyalty.

Jim Collins

For the shape of leadership that builds something lasting.

Peter Drucker

For what a business is actually for.

Dale Carnegie

For the observation that genuine interest in the other person is not a technique.

Robert Greenleaf

For servant leadership: the leader is the one who serves first.

Otian AI LLC. Written by Jett Nguyen and Jack Raney. Questions, disagreements, and accusations of hypocrisy are all welcome at the contact address on our site.

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